Encyclopedia Brown and the Case of the Barefoot Thieves

By Donald J. Sobol

Police officers across America were asking the same question. Why did everyone who broke the law in Idaville get caught? Idaville looked like many seaside towns its size. It had delicatessens, three movie theatres, and four banks. It had churches, a synagogue, and lovely white beaches. And it had a certain Red Brick house on Rover Avenue. In the house lived Idaville's secret weapon against law breakers—ten year old Encyclopedia Brown.

Mr. Brown was the chief of the Idaville police force. He was proud of his men. But he was not too proud to get them help. Whenever Chief Brown came up against a case that no on the force could solve, he knew what to do. He went home and ate dinner. Before the meal was over, Encyclopedia had solved the case for him. Chief Brown wanted to tell the world about his only child—to announce over satellite television "my son is the greatest detective who ever shot a water pistol!" But what good would it do? Who would believe that the mastermind behind Idaville's spotless police record was only a fifth-grader?

Encyclopedia never let slip a work about the help he gave his father. He didn't want to seem different from other boys his age. But there was nothing he could do about his nickname. Only his parents and teachers called him by his real name, Leroy. Everyone else called him Encyclopedia. An Encyclopedia is a book or set of books filled with facts from A to Z—just like Encyclopedia's head. He had read more books that anyone in Idaville, and he never forgot what he read. All this knowledge gave him the ability to start his very own, Brown Detective Agency.

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INTRODUCTION

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NARRATOR: Tyrone Taylor knew how to treat the fair sex. He was the only boy in Idaville who got up to give a girl his seat- even when they were the only two passengers on the bus. The other fifth grade boys called him Sir Galahad. Monday afternoon Tyrone came into the Brown Detective Agency. He looked sick as a horse.

TYRONE: *(sadly)* Don't call me Sir Galahad . . . call me Sir Had-a-Gal.

ENCYCLOPEDIA: Who was it this time?

TYRONE: Betty Holden. Just when I figured I had a chance with her, what happens? She goes out with Stingy Stenson!

ENCYCLOPEDIA: Don't worry. Stingy is so tight that if he blinks his eyes, his knuckles crack. When he dates a girl, the money flows like glue

TYRONE: That's what I thought. But last night I saw them together in Mr. O'Hara's drugstore. Stingy bought her the Idaville Special with *three* scoops of ice cream!

ENCYCLOPEDIA: Wow! That costs twenty cents extra!

TYRONE: I want to hire you. *(slams a quarter on the gasoline can beside Encyclopedia).* Find out where Stingy stole the money he's spending.

ENCYCLOPEDIA: Just a minute. You can't go around accusing him of stealing --

TYRONE: *(snapping)* What was he doing outside the Medical Building yesterday morning? It was Sunday. The building was closed. And you should have seen his crazy walk.

ENCYCLOPEDIA: *(scratching his head)* You better show me.

NARRATOR: The two boys biked to the Medical building. It was after five o'clock when they arrived. The doctors had all gone home. The parking lot was empty.

TYRONE: Sunday was a hot day. So I sat under that shade tree while I thought about Betty. Suddenly I saw Stingy and his big brother Pete. They were walking in the parking lot, one behind the other. Crazy!

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ENCYCLOPEDIA: Crazy?

TYRONE: They walked as if they couldn't keep their balance. Then they jumped into a red truck that had "Mac's Service Station" written on the door. They drove away, *zoom*!

ENCYCLOPEDIA: Sit under the same tree. I'll do what they did

NARRATOR: He went down to the parking lot, which was enclosed by a seven-foot stonewall. He walked across the blacktop surface till he could see Tyrone over the wall.

TYRONE: Stingy and Pete were farther back. I can see only your head above the wall. I saw them down to the waist. (Encyclopedia moved back a few steps.) Stop! That's where they were

NARRATOR: Encyclopedia had halted on a long, narrow white line. Branching out on either side of it were short white lines to mark spaces for cars to park.

ENCYCLOPEDIA: Stingy and Pete were walking a narrow white line you can't see from there! They were having fun keeping their balance

TYRONE: Fun, nothing. They were celebrating. They probably just robbed some doctor's office.

NARRATOR: Tyrone refused to believe anything but the worst about Stingy. He made Encyclopedia promise to ask his father if the medical building had been robbed yesterday. At dinner, Encyclopedia put the question to his father.

MR. BROWN: Why yes, Officer Clancy handled the case. I learned about it this morning. Thieves took about two hundred dollars altogether from the petty-cash boxes in several offices.

ENCYCLOPEDIA: Isn't the medical building locked on Sunday?

MR. BROWN: The front door lock was broken Saturday. A watchman was hired till it could be repaired today

ENCYCLOPEDIA: Where was the watchman during the robbery?

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MR. BROWN: He was drinking at the water fountain when he glimpsed two pairs of bare feet disappearing us the stairs. He chased them. As he turned a corner, he was struck and knocked out. He awoke to see Mac's red service truck leave the parking lot. The watchman telephoned Mac immediately. Sundays, the truck is driven by Pete Stetson. Sometimes he takes his younger brother, the one everyone calls Stingy, along on service calls. When they returned to the station, both boys had on shoes

ENCYCLOPEDIA: What were the Stetson boys doing at the parking lot?

MR. BROWN: Pete says he was looking for a key, which he thought he dropped Saturday after visiting Dr. Marshall. He did see the doctor. We checked on that. No doubt the thieves removed their shoes in order to walk more quietly. Pete and Stingy may have robbed the offices. But we can't shake their alibi.

ENCYCLOPEDIA: You mean, you need a clue to prove they had their shoes off when they entered the building?

MR. BROWN: One clue will do, but we don't even have one!

ENCYCLOPEDIA: *(grinning)* I have!

NARRATOR: Pete and Stingy had taken off their shoes and socks in the truck in order to walk quietly. They had entered and left the building by walking along the white stripes of the parking lot. As they left, Tyrone Taylor had sat down under the tree. The brothers did not see him. But he saw them, from the waist up, walking back to the truck. Encyclopedia realized the brothers had not walked along the sidewalk just for fun. It was a hot day, remember? The blacktop burned their feet. So they had walked along the white strip—which was cooler. Faced with proof revealed by Tyrone's sharp eyes and Encyclopedia's sharp brain, the Stetson brothers confessed. Thanks to Encyclopedia, the money was returned and Tyrone—I mean, Sir Galahad, got the girl.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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